history guaranteed the spectacle would be all the more striking, hence the touch of circumspection. Also because, at fifty, Nishant is at an unusual age for a dynastic political debutant. The very recourse to him spoke of a certain vacuum.

Takeaways

- Nishant Kumar, 50, formally joins JD(U), likely to be deputy CM
- Nitish's forthcoming shift to RS made party look to his untested son

AN ECHO OF NITISH

A computer engineer educated at the Birla Institute of Technology, Mesra, he lived much of his adult life away from politics. Described by acquaintances as reserved and soft-spoken, he has avoided the assertive tone common to many political heirs. That reserve has paradoxically become an asset: senior JD(U) leaders see in him a temperamental echo of his father—cautious, courteous, serious—reassuring traits for a party defined by Nitish's personality.

The back story, too, paints a soft, sensitive persona. Fondly called Nishi by friends and family, he was born on July 20, 1975—barely a month after Emergency. His father was cutting his teeth politically in the JP movement. Nishant rarely saw him at home and grew especially close to his schoolteacher mother, Manju Sinha, who largely raised him on her own. Initially enrolled at St Karen's school, Patna, Nitish shifted him to a boarding school in Mussoorie after an unpleasant episode in which a teacher reportedly struck him. Nishant struggled with the separation and eventually returned to complete his schooling at Patna's Kendriya Vidyalaya. As the son of a rising politician, he kept an unusually low profile. In 1999, when Nitish was Union railway minister, he preferred to share a train berth with a friend, and not reveal his identity to seek a confirmed seat.

After his BTech in 2002, he chose not to pursue a career and instead returned to live with his mother and maternal grandparents. Following his mother's death in 2007, he moved into the CM's residence at 1, Anne Marg, with his father and extended family. Family friends recall that Nitish, too, appeared increasingly protective of his son, preferring that he remain close to home rather than embark on a career elsewhere.

A career has begun, nonetheless, one with its own erratic algorithms. For now, things seem programmed: meetings with party leaders, posters proclaiming him as the inheritor of a legacy, the harbinger of a "new chapter". Some JD(U) leaders suggest he would soon lead the legislative group, after joining the legislative council, and become deputy CM.

FATHER FIGURE

That betokens a larger transition: a new chief minister, likely from the BJP, with Nitish set to enter the Rajya Sabha this month. Few expect him to vanish from the scene. The assumption in the party is that he will remain in Patna, guiding the transition from behind the scenes. A new residence has been earmarked for him in the city, where he is expected to continue mentoring his son and steering strategy—effectively remaining the intellectual and moral anchor for the JD(U).

But how Nishant evolves from here, learning on the job, will be crucial to that transition. The JD(U) will need a father figure—a son is auditioning for that role. ■

▶ PUNJAB

Mann's Dole for Women

Punjab's Rs 9,300 crore direct welfare scheme brings to focus the state's key fiscal challenges

By **Anilesh S. Mahajan**

TEXTBOOK ECONOMICS SAYS IT'S TIME FOR fiscal prudence. But this is also Punjab's last full budget before the state heads into an assembly election in early 2027. Politically speaking, it was no surprise then to see Bhagwant Mann's finance minister, Harpal Singh Cheema, roll out a Rs 2.6 lakh crore budget for FY27, the largest in the state's history. The Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) is clearly leaving no stone unturned as it seeks to retain its only government.

The headline announcement is one that's familiar by now. Only the name is in Punjabi: the Mukh Mantri Mawan Dhiyan Satikar Yojna (the CM's Scheme for the Respect of Mothers and Daughters). In form and content, it echoes what many election-facing state governments have offered. Reciprocal respect is usually meant to be earned, but it can also be induced. This one seeks to do so with a Rs 9,300 crore payout formula in which all eligible women will get Rs 1,000 per month, while Scheduled Caste women will get Rs 1,500. The coverage: nearly 97 per cent of Punjab's adult women.

Politically, the scheme fulfils one of AAP's biggest promises from the 2022 campaign and places its government firmly within a broader national trend. In economic terms, however, it calls attention to Punjab's tight fiscal situation. Its